

you seen the true-crime documentary *The Staircase* because omg, there's no way an *OWL* killed her!!!)

GO SHOPPING. There are also other types of cards: A store credit card is like those Macy's or JCPenney's cards you're offered whenever you're at a department store register. You can use some of these cards only at the corresponding store, but they can really help you build your credit until you can get a "real" card. A secured credit card is one you put "a cash collateral deposit" down on before you can use it. If you put \$500 in the account, you can charge up to \$500 on the card. (This is good for someone who would have trouble getting a regular credit card but needs one for booking travel or buying online.) Once you have a handle on your credit and can manage a simple credit card, you can start using points if you want.

HIT UP REDDIT. Conflicting opinions abound on credit cards! One good place to find them is—drumroll please—Reddit! There's a subreddit devoted to credit card tips and tricks. I know Reddit has a scary reputation, but that segment of the site has great advice on getting your score up and updated information on which cards are the best for what. Just don't click around to any other subreddits. It's a rabbit hole. If you're not cozy with Reddit, you can go on the myFico forum, where people post advice on topics like student loans, car loans, mortgages, and of course, credit cards.

PATIENCE, YOUNG GRASSHOPPER. Once you apply for a card, you'll know within minutes if you've been approved (if the site has instant approval, which most do). The bank or company will pull your credit score, then ask your income and some other basic information to approve you and set your credit limit. (My credit limit on my Bank of America card is \$5,000, while my credit limit on my American Express card, which I applied for while I was more financially solvent, is \$10,000.) You can also apply for a credit card over the phone or by mail.